

Ethics Learned at a Distance: Distributed Entry, Ethical Imprinting, and the Generation Z Question

Abstract

Newcomers learn which ethical norms a workplace actually practices mostly by watching how colleagues handle ethically charged situations and what happens afterwards. This became a problem for many recent entrants to office-based work, including many members of Generation Z, whose entry period took place partly at a distance. This paper develops a conceptual model of ethical socialization under distributed entry, grounded in social learning theory and imprinting theory. It proposes that distributed entry reduces newcomers' clarity about enacted ethical norms by limiting their observational access to ethical conduct in the work unit, and that leaders who narrate the ethical reasoning behind decisions can offset part of this loss. It further proposes that distance weakens the transmission of a unit's enacted norms whatever their ethical quality, a loss where norms are ethical and a partial protection where misconduct is normal, and that these differences persist beyond entry and follow entry conditions rather than birth cohort. The paper reports no data; it suggests implications for onboarding and outlines designs for testing the five propositions in field and experimental settings.

Keywords: Generation Z, workplace ethics, organizational socialization, social learning theory, imprinting, remote work

1 Introduction

Organizations convey ethical norms in two ways. One is written down in codes of conduct and training modules. The other is practiced: it is visible in which shortcuts are tolerated, which objections are taken seriously, and what happens to people who bend a rule or refuse to. Newcomers learn the first set by reading. They learn the second mainly by watching. A study of new accountants found that newcomers obtained normative information chiefly through observation and chiefly from peers (Morrison, 1993), and research on ethical leadership rests on the premise that followers learn what is expected by observing leaders whose conduct serves as a model (Brown et al., 2005). How well newcomers learn the practiced norms therefore depends on how much of that practice they can see.

For a large group of recent entrants, much less of it was visible. Working from home spread rapidly in 2020 (Kniffin et al., 2021). When one large firm moved to fully remote work, its employees' collaboration networks became more siloed and their communication more asynchronous (Yang et al., 2022), and newcomers onboarded remotely report fewer interactions with insiders (Paik and Gilmore, 2026). Among those starting their first office-based jobs in this period were many members of Generation Z, as that cohort is commonly defined. It is plausible, although we have found no data that establish it, that a substantial share of them spent part of their entry period at a distance from the colleagues whose conduct would otherwise have taught them the practiced norms.

As far as we can tell, the question has not been asked, in part because the relevant literatures have developed separately. Research on ethical leadership and socialization explains how ethical norms pass from experienced members to newcomers, but it has studied settings in which the two share space (Brown et al., 2005). Research on remote work and remote onboarding documents the loss of everyday interaction, but it examines adjustment, relationships, and performance rather than ethics (Paik and Gilmore, 2026). Imprinting research shows that conditions at the start of a career leave durable marks, but its outcomes have been performance and professional orientation (Tilcsik, 2014). Research on generations, for its part, has concentrated on whether cohorts differ in their values. None of these literatures asks what newcomers learn about workplace ethics when they enter at a distance, or whether it lasts.

This framing also departs from the usual way of connecting Generation Z and workplace ethics, which asks whether the cohort holds different ethical values. The evidence for generational differences in work attitudes and values is weak and difficult to separate from age and period effects (Costanza et al., 2012; Rudolph et al., 2021), although the debate is not settled (Campbell et al., 2015). We ask instead how members of the cohort learned the ethics of their workplaces. That question returns to Mannheim's view that a cohort becomes a generation through shared formative experiences (Mannheim, 1952), and to the distinction between generations defined by age and generations defined by entering an organization at the same time (Joshi et al., 2010).

Two terms need definition. By workplace ethics we mean the standards of conduct that govern how members of an organization treat one another, clients, and others affected by their work, as those standards are both stated and practiced. Research on ethical infrastructure separates the formal elements that state such standards from the informal elements that convey how they are actually applied (Tenbrunsel et al., 2003), and our focus is on the latter. By an ethically charged situation we mean one in which a decision affects the interests of others and the right course is contested or unclear, such as a request to shade a report or to overlook a colleague's shortcut. By Generation Z we mean the cohort that followed the Millennials into the labor market. Its birth-year boundaries are set by convention and vary across sources, so we use the label descriptively.

We develop a conceptual model of ethical socialization under distributed entry grounded in two established theories. Social learning theory explains how enacted norms are acquired through observation of others and of the consequences they experience (Bandura, 1977). Imprinting theory explains why characteristics formed during a sensitive period persist after conditions change (Marquis and Tilcsik, 2013). The model proposes that distributed entry reduces newcomers' clarity about enacted ethical norms by limiting their observational access to ethical conduct, and that leaders who explicitly narrate the ethical reasoning behind their decisions can offset part of this loss. It also proposes a two-sided effect: because distance weakens the transmission of enacted norms in general, it deprives newcomers of good examples in ethical units but also shields them in part from misconduct that has become normal elsewhere. The final propositions concern whether these effects persist after the entry period and whether they follow the conditions of entry rather than birth cohort.

The two-sided prediction is the part of the model with the most practical weight. Discussions of remote work and ethics tend to ask whether distance makes employees behave better or worse. If the model is right, that question has no single answer, because the effect of distance on a newcomer depends on the norms of the unit the newcomer joins. The prediction also distinguishes our account from a simpler one in which distance reduces supervision and so creates more room for misconduct everywhere. The two accounts make different predictions for units in which misconduct is already normal, which gives research a way to tell them apart.

The paper makes three contributions, all of which remain to be tested.

- It treats ethical socialization as a transmission process whose fidelity depends on observational access, and it introduces enacted-norm clarity and leader ethical narration as constructs for studying that process when newcomers and their models do not share space. Existing ethical leadership research explains role modeling well but assumes co-presence (Brown et al., 2005).
- It proposes that distance weakens the transmission of unethical as well as ethical norms. Research on the normalization of corruption shows that newcomers can be socialized into misconduct (Ashforth and Anand, 2003); our model implies that the channel through which this happens can narrow, and it yields a prediction that distinguishes a learning account of remote-work misconduct from an account based on reduced monitoring.
- It extends imprinting theory, which has linked entry conditions to later performance (Tilcsik, 2014), to ethical norms, and it relocates the Generation Z question in the conditions of organizational entry, stated as a proposition that research can confirm or reject.

2 Literature Review

The model draws on three bodies of work that rarely cite one another. We review what each establishes, note what it leaves open, and close with the connection none of them makes.

2.1 How Newcomers Learn Ethical Norms

Organizational socialization research treats entry as the period in which newcomers learn how things are done. Van Maanen and Schein (1979) treated socialization as the way people come to acquire the social knowledge and skills that an organizational role demands, and they classified the tactics organizations use to structure it. Institutionalized tactics, in which newcomers move through shared, structured experiences, were later associated with lower role ambiguity and stronger identification (Ashforth and Saks, 1996). A meta-analysis identified role clarity, self-efficacy, and social acceptance as indicators of newcomer adjustment that link socialization tactics and information seeking to later outcomes (Bauer et al., 2007).

One of the tactic dimensions in Van Maanen and Schein’s typology is especially relevant here. They contrasted serial socialization, in which experienced members who have held a role groom newcomers to take it on, with disjunctive socialization, in which no such predecessors are available and newcomers have to work out the role largely on their own. Serial tactics give newcomers models to observe. The distinction was drawn with the availability of predecessors in mind, not physical distance, but it suggests a useful way to describe what distributed entry may do: newcomers who formally have experienced colleagues may in practice see so little of them that their situation comes to resemble disjunctive socialization.

Several strands of this research point to observation and interaction as the main channels. Newcomers make sense of the surprises of entry partly through the interpretations insiders offer (Louis, 1980), and the frequency of interaction with insiders has been proposed as a main determinant of how quickly socialization proceeds (Reichers, 1987). In a study of how newcomers acquire different kinds of information, normative information was obtained mainly by observation and mainly from peers (Morrison, 1993).

Ethical norms are learned through the same channels. Early work found that subordinates’ behavior came to resemble that of superiors they regarded as competent and successful (Weiss, 1977). Ethical leadership research built on this idea, defining ethical leaders in part as role models whose conduct, communication, and use of rewards and discipline show followers what is expected (Brown et al., 2005; Brown and Treviño, 2006). Evidence on ethical leadership is consistent with this account. A meta-analysis found that ethical leadership was positively associated with followers’ ethical behavior (Bedi et al., 2016), and a multilevel study found that ethical leadership by top management was

related to group outcomes through ethical leadership by supervisors (Mayer et al., 2009). Peers matter too: employees’ antisocial behavior has been found to track that of their coworkers (Robinson and O’Leary-Kelly, 1998).

Behavioral ethics research has examined influences on ethical conduct at several levels (Treviño et al., 2006), and meta-analytic evidence links features of the organizational environment, alongside characteristics of individuals and of the moral issue, to unethical choices (Kish-Gephart et al., 2010). Within that environment, researchers distinguish formal elements, such as codes, training, and official sanctions, from informal elements carried by everyday interaction (Tenbrunsel et al., 2003), and they separate ethical culture from ethical climate as related but distinct features of the ethical context (Treviño et al., 1998). In that study, a culture-based dimension of the ethical context was more strongly associated with observed unethical conduct in organizations that had codes of conduct, while climate-based dimensions mattered more in organizations without codes. Having a code, in other words, did not settle what was practiced. This distinction is central to our argument. Formal elements can be delivered to a newcomer anywhere. Informal elements, which tell a newcomer what is actually done, are the ones this literature ties most closely to interaction and observation.

What this body of work does not examine is what happens to ethical learning when the channels it relies on narrow. Its studies were conducted, and its theories developed, largely under the assumption that newcomers share space with the people they learn from.

2.2 What Working at a Distance Changes

Research on telework predates the recent spread of remote work and gives a mixed but informative picture. A meta-analysis found small, mostly favorable effects of telecommuting on outcomes such as perceived autonomy and work-family conflict, with the exception that high-intensity telecommuting was associated with worse coworker relationships (Gajendran and Harrison, 2007). A later review reached a similar overall conclusion while emphasizing that effects depend on how and how much telework is used (Allen et al., 2015). Professional isolation was more harmful to teleworkers’ performance the more time they spent teleworking, and less harmful the more face-to-face interaction they had (Golden et al., 2008).

The move to widespread working from home in 2020 raised these questions at a larger scale (Kniffin et al., 2021). In one large firm, the shift to firm-wide remote work made employees’ collaboration networks more static and siloed and moved communication toward asynchronous media (Yang et al., 2022). A qualitative study of newcomers onboarded remotely found that, although they became proficient at their jobs, they had fewer interactions with insiders, experienced ambiguity about their membership, and found insider support insufficient (Paik and Gilmore, 2026). The same newcomers compensated

with proactive behavior, seeking out the contact that did not come to them. That finding matters for our purposes because it implies that distant newcomers learn what they think to ask about, which is a narrower set of things than what co-located newcomers happen to see.

The common thread in these studies is that distance removes the unplanned and ambient part of work more than its scheduled part. Planned meetings continue, while the chance encounters, overheard conversations, and visible reactions that fill the time between them become rarer. Much of socialization research suggests that newcomers learn a great deal from exactly this unplanned part of work (Reichers, 1987).

Digital tools can restore some visibility. An enterprise social platform that made employees' messages visible to colleagues improved observers' knowledge of who knew what and who knew whom (Leonardi, 2015). That finding concerns knowledge of expertise and connections, not ethical norms, but it shows that mediated channels can carry some of the ambient information that co-presence supplies.

In our reading, much of the earlier telework research also studied employees who had already been socialized in their organizations before they began working remotely. Newcomers who start at a distance are a different case, because they have no stock of previously observed norms to draw on. This literature has concentrated on performance, relationships, well-being, and adjustment. We found no study that examines how distance changes what newcomers learn about ethical norms.

2.3 Generations, Cohorts, and Conditions of Entry

The sociological concept of a generation goes back to Mannheim (1952), who argued that people born in the same period share a location in history but become a generation in a fuller sense only through shared formative experiences. Mannheim also expected people within the same broad cohort to respond to those experiences in different ways, so that a single cohort could contain several distinct groupings. His account therefore gives little support to the idea that everyone born within a span of years shares a common outlook. Workplace research has mostly used birth-year cohorts instead. Reviews of that research describe the evidence for generational differences in work values and attitudes as mixed, largely descriptive, and hard to separate from age and period effects (Parry and Urwin, 2011; Lyons and Kuron, 2014), and a meta-analysis found differences in job satisfaction, commitment, and turnover intentions to be small (Costanza et al., 2012). One of these reviews concluded that the field had done much more to describe differences than to explain why a generation should differ at all (Lyons and Kuron, 2014).

The field remains divided. One focal article argued that there is little solid evidence for generationally based differences at work and little theory explaining why they should exist (Costanza and Finkelstein, 2015), while a commentary defended generational differences

as real and useful (Campbell et al., 2015). Critics have proposed replacing generational explanations with a lifespan developmental perspective (Rudolph and Zacher, 2017) and have challenged a series of common claims about generations (Rudolph et al., 2021).

A different line of work keeps the idea of generations but changes its basis. Joshi et al. (2010) distinguished age-based generational identities from cohort-based ones formed when people enter an organization or experience at the same time. That distinction, together with Mannheim’s emphasis on formative experience, opens a route that the value-difference debate has not taken: asking whether the conditions under which a cohort entered working life left a lasting mark on what it learned. The route does not require settling the debate between critics and defenders of generational research. It requires only that entry conditions can be measured and that their effects can be compared across newcomers of different ages, which is the approach taken in our final proposition.

Taken together, these literatures leave a specific gap. Socialization and ethical leadership research explain how ethical norms are learned through observation but assume co-presence. Telework and remote-onboarding research documents the loss of interaction but not its ethical consequences. Imprinting research shows that conditions at entry leave durable traces, but it has studied performance and professional orientation (Tilcsik, 2014; Azoulay et al., 2017) rather than ethics. Generational research has focused on value levels. No existing model links distributed entry to the transmission and persistence of enacted ethical norms, and none considers that distance might weaken the transmission of unethical norms as well as ethical ones. The closest studies each supply one piece: remote-onboarding research the loss of contact with insiders, socialization research the importance of observation for normative learning, and imprinting research the durability of what is learned at entry. The model developed below joins these pieces around ethical norms.

3 Theoretical Framework and Approach

3.1 Approach

This article develops theory and does not test it. Its design corresponds to what Jaakkola (2020) calls a model paper, in which the author specifies constructs and the relationships among them and argues for why those relationships should hold. Following Whetten (1989), we try to be explicit about which factors are included, how they connect, and what logic links them. Because the central claims concern how an outcome varies across conditions, we state them as propositions, the format that Cornelissen (2017) associates with theorizing about contingent relationships. Throughout the paper, a claim attributed to a cited study reports what that study found or argued. Claims that are ours are flagged as such, and none of them has been tested.

3.2 Social Learning Theory

Social learning theory holds that people acquire much of what they do by watching others and noting what happens to them, as well as by acting and experiencing consequences directly (Bandura, 1977). Bandura later broadened the account into a social cognitive theory in which personal factors, behavior, and the environment influence one another (Bandura, 1986). Applied to organizations, observational learning has been described as running through attention to a model, retention of what was seen, reproduction of the behavior, and motivation to act on it (Manz and Sims, 1981). Early field work found that subordinates' behavior resembled that of their superiors more closely when the superiors were seen as competent and successful (Weiss, 1977), and the same author extended the argument from behavior to work values (Weiss, 1978).

The theory is also the main foundation of research on ethical leadership. Brown et al. (2005) defined ethical leaders partly as credible role models whose conduct followers observe and emulate, and whose communication, rewards, and discipline signal which conduct is expected. A later review drew heavily on social learning reasoning to explain why ethical leadership affects followers (Brown and Treviño, 2006). Bandura also recognized that people learn from verbal and symbolic models, such as descriptions and depictions of conduct, and not only from live ones (Bandura, 1977). Recent theory adds that vicarious learning need not require silent observation: it can also happen in conversation, when people jointly work through what one of them experienced (Myers, 2018).

In our reading, each of these steps can be affected by distance. Attention requires that a model be present to attend to, and retention and reproduction depend on having seen a behavior clearly enough to remember and repeat it. Motivation depends partly on what learners see happen to the model afterwards. Bandura called this last element vicarious reinforcement: observing that others are rewarded or punished for a behavior informs a learner's expectations about what will follow if the learner acts the same way (Bandura, 1977). We suggest that for ethical norms vicarious reinforcement is often the decisive element, because what an organization rewards and punishes in practice is what distinguishes its enacted norms from its stated ones.

Two features of the theory make it fit our problem. It locates the learning of norms in exposure to models and to the consequences that follow their conduct, so any change in exposure should change what is learned. And it treats the consequences others experience as information, which is precisely the kind of information that tells a newcomer which ethical norms are enforced rather than merely stated.

3.3 Imprinting Theory

The idea of imprinting entered organization theory through Stinchcombe (1965), who observed that organizations bear lasting marks of the period in which they were founded.

Marquis and Tilcsik (2013) generalized the idea across levels of analysis: during a brief sensitive period, an entity develops characteristics that reflect prominent features of its environment, and those characteristics persist after the environment changes. They also separated imprinting from related ideas, including path dependence and cohort effects.

At the level of individuals, research has linked early career conditions to lasting patterns. A longitudinal study of professionals found that the economic conditions of their organization at the time of hire shaped the approaches they developed during socialization and, through those approaches, their later performance (Tilcsik, 2014). Young scientists have been shown to adopt their advisers' orientation toward commercial science (Azoulay et al., 2017). Organizations have been described as leaving career imprints that employees carry into later roles (Higgins, 2005), and prior work experience has been found to carry over in ways that can hinder performance in a new setting (Dokko et al., 2009).

The concept of a sensitive period is central to this literature. Imprinting is not expected to happen at any moment, but during periods in which an entity is unusually open to its environment, and periods of transition, such as founding or entry into a new setting, are commonly discussed examples (Marquis and Tilcsik, 2013). In our view, entry into a first professional job has several such features for an individual: the newcomer has few established routines, is actively trying to learn what is expected, and has little prior experience against which to compare what the organization presents.

Imprinting theory fits our problem because it explains what social learning theory leaves open: why learning that happens at entry should matter after entry. It directs attention to the conditions present during the sensitive period, and it predicts that later exposure will not fully overwrite what was formed then.

3.4 Why These Two Theories

The two theories answer different questions, which is why we use both. Social learning theory explains how enacted ethical norms are acquired and why the channel of exposure matters. Imprinting theory explains why the result of that acquisition, including its gaps, persists. We considered and set aside several alternatives. Sensemaking accounts of entry (Louis, 1980) explain how newcomers interpret surprises but not why early interpretations endure. Research on ethical climate and culture describes the content that newcomers learn, and we draw on it for that purpose, but it does not specify the learning process. Identity-based accounts of generations (Joshi et al., 2010) help us define which cohort matters, but they are not a theory of how ethical norms are transmitted. A control or monitoring perspective would predict that distance increases opportunities for misconduct; we treat it as a rival explanation and return to it in the discussion.

3.5 Scope Conditions

The model applies to office-based and knowledge work, where distributed arrangements are feasible, and to the entry period in a new organization, with entry into a first professional job as the clearest case. It concerns the ethical norms of the work unit a newcomer joins, especially in the gray areas where written rules leave room for judgment and enacted norms therefore carry most weight; that emphasis is our assumption. It does not address roles that cannot be performed remotely, and it takes no position on whether distributed work is good or bad overall.

4 Conceptual Model and Propositions

4.1 Overview

Figure 1 summarizes the model. Its starting point is distributed entry, meaning that a newcomer spends much of the entry period working apart from supervisors and colleagues. The model proposes that distributed entry reduces observational access to ethical conduct and, through it, the newcomer’s clarity about the ethical norms the work unit actually practices. Leaders who narrate the ethical reasoning behind their decisions can offset part of this loss. Because clarity about enacted norms is what allows those norms to shape a newcomer’s conduct, distributed entry weakens their influence whether they are ethical or not. The effects are proposed to persist after the entry period and to follow the conditions of entry rather than birth cohort. Each arrow in the figure is a proposition that has not been tested.

4.2 Constructs

Distributed entry is the extent to which a newcomer’s entry period is spent working physically apart from supervisors and colleagues, whether through fully remote or hybrid arrangements. It is a property of work arrangements, measured by how much of the newcomer’s time, and how much of the time of the people the newcomer works with, is spent in shared space.

Observational access to ethical conduct is our own construct. We define it as the newcomer’s opportunity to see, directly or through channels that make conduct visible, how members of the work unit handle ethically charged situations and what happens to them afterwards. It follows from the emphasis social learning theory places on exposure to models and their consequences (Bandura, 1977). It is also related to the transparency dimension of ethical culture in Kaptein’s model, which concerns how visible conduct and its consequences are within an organization (Kaptein, 2008), but it is defined for the individual newcomer rather than for the organization.

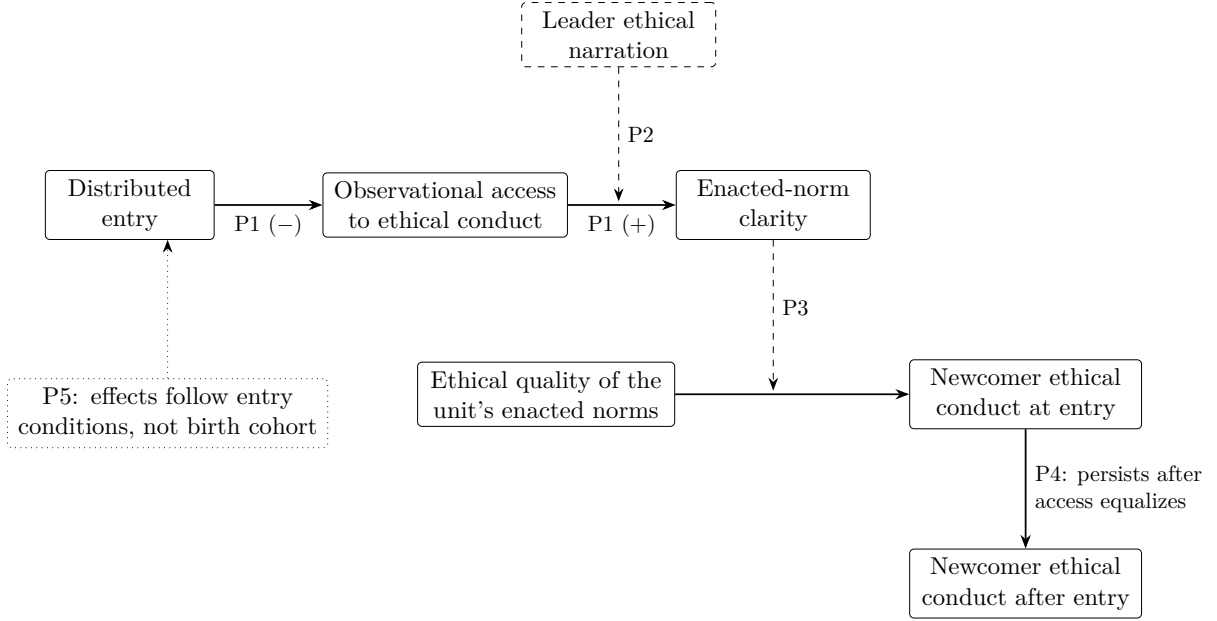


Figure 1: The distributed ethical socialization model. Solid arrows show proposed main relationships. P1: distributed entry lowers observational access, which lowers enacted-norm clarity. P2: leader ethical narration makes enacted-norm clarity depend less on observational access, weakening the negative effect of distributed entry. P3: enacted-norm clarity strengthens the influence of the unit’s enacted norms on newcomer conduct, whatever their ethical quality, so distributed entry weakens that influence. P4: the resulting differences persist after the entry period. P5: the relationships follow conditions of entry rather than birth cohort. All paths are untested propositions.

Enacted-norm clarity is also our own construct: the newcomer’s understanding of which conduct is actually practiced, rewarded, tolerated, and sanctioned in the work unit when ethical considerations arise. It differs from knowledge of the organization’s code of conduct, which concerns espoused norms. The distinction follows research on ethical infrastructure, which separates formal elements such as codes and training from informal elements such as the norms conveyed through everyday interaction (Tenbrunsel et al., 2003), and it parallels role clarity, one of the indicators of newcomer adjustment in socialization research (Bauer et al., 2007).

Leader ethical narration, the third of our own constructs, is the extent to which supervisors explicitly explain the ethical considerations behind their decisions, and the consequences of others’ conduct, in settings a newcomer can access. It isolates one element of ethical leadership, the explicit communication of ethical expectations (Brown et al., 2005), which is also part of what Treviño et al. (2000) called being a moral manager.

The ethical quality of enacted norms is the degree to which the conduct a work unit practices and tolerates is ethical, running from units whose enacted norms support ethical conduct to units in which misconduct has become normal. It draws on research on ethical culture (Treviño et al., 1998; Kaptein, 2008) and on the normalization of corruption (Ashforth and Anand, 2003). Newcomer ethical conduct is the newcomer’s

behavior in ethically relevant situations, such as honesty in reporting and the treatment of colleagues and clients.

Two design choices deserve explanation. We treat enacted-norm clarity, not knowledge of formal codes, as the mediator because formal content travels well at a distance and is therefore unlikely to carry the effect of distributed entry. We include the ethical quality of enacted norms as a moderator rather than assuming that the norms being transmitted are ethical, because the socialization literature documents that newcomers can be socialized into misconduct as readily as into integrity (Ashforth and Anand, 2003).

4.3 Distributed Entry and Enacted-Norm Clarity

Socialization research gives observation a central place in how newcomers learn norms. In a study of new accountants, newcomers sought technical information mainly by asking others, but sought other types of information, including normative information, mainly by observing, and they obtained normative information mostly from peers (Morrison, 1993). Interaction with insiders has long been treated as the main vehicle of early socialization and a determinant of how quickly it proceeds (Reichers, 1987), and insiders help newcomers interpret the surprises that entry produces (Louis, 1980).

Research on distributed work suggests that these channels narrow at a distance. A meta-analysis found that telecommuting was not generally harmful to workplace relationships, but that high-intensity telecommuting was associated with worse relationships with coworkers (Gajendran and Harrison, 2007). Professional isolation was more damaging to performance for teleworkers who spent more time teleworking and less damaging for those with more face-to-face interaction (Golden et al., 2008). When a large technology firm moved to firm-wide remote work, its employees' collaboration networks became more static and siloed, and communication shifted toward asynchronous media (Yang et al., 2022). Newcomers onboarded remotely described fewer interactions with insiders and found insider support insufficient (Paik and Gilmore, 2026).

The step from these findings to ethics is our own argument. Ethically charged situations are episodic, and how they are handled is often visible mainly to those present: the hesitation before a decision, the reaction of a senior colleague, what later happens to the person who cut a corner or refused to. Asynchronous written channels tend to record decisions more readily than the reasoning and consequences around them, and consequences are what vicarious learning draws on. Formal ethics content, by contrast, can be delivered remotely with little loss. A newcomer who enters at a distance may therefore know the espoused norms well while knowing the enacted norms poorly, which is the gap between formal and informal systems that ethical infrastructure research describes (Tenbrunsel et al., 2003).

One might expect newcomers simply to ask about what they cannot see. Research

on feedback seeking suggests why asking is a poor substitute where ethics is concerned. People seek information either by inquiry or by monitoring, and inquiry carries image costs because it can reveal uncertainty or incompetence (Ashford et al., 2003). Questions about ethical norms carry a further cost that we infer rather than draw from evidence: asking whether a practice is really acceptable can signal naivety, or suspicion of colleagues. Distance removes much of the monitoring route and leaves the costlier inquiry route, so we expect distant newcomers to acquire less normative information, not merely to acquire it differently.

Proposition 1. Distributed entry is negatively related to newcomers’ enacted-norm clarity, and reduced observational access to ethical conduct carries this relationship.

4.4 Leader Ethical Narration as an Offset

If distributed entry removes observation, the question becomes whether explicit communication can replace some of what observation would have supplied. Research on ethical leadership suggests that the explicit side of leadership matters. Executives earn a reputation for ethical leadership partly by making ethics a visible part of how they lead, including talking about values and using rewards and discipline in ways others can see (Treviño et al., 2000). Ethical leadership has been associated with followers’ ethical behavior across studies (Bedi et al., 2016), and its effects have been found to travel from top management through supervisors to work groups (Mayer et al., 2009).

Social learning theory itself allows for this possibility, since it recognizes learning from verbal and symbolic models as well as live ones (Bandura, 1977). The question is whether mediated channels actually carry the relevant models and consequences, and our argument in the previous section was that, left to themselves, they often do not. Two further strands support the idea that deliberate communication can close part of the gap. Vicarious learning can occur through conversation about others’ experiences as well as through watching them (Myers, 2018). Social media, including the internal platforms many organizations use, afford visibility and persistence of communication (Treem and Leonardi, 2013), and when an enterprise social platform made employees’ communications visible to colleagues, those colleagues became better informed about who knew what and who knew whom (Leonardi, 2015). Our argument is that a supervisor who explains, in a team meeting or a written update, why a borderline request was refused and what happened when someone ignored a rule turns tacit enacted norms into information a distant newcomer can acquire.

Proposition 2. Leader ethical narration weakens the negative relationship between distributed entry and newcomers’ enacted-norm clarity.

Narration has a limit. It carries only what leaders are willing to say. Practices that

contradict an organization's stated values are rarely narrated, a point that becomes important in the next proposition.

4.5 A Two-Sided Effect

Observation transmits bad norms as well as good ones. The normalization of corruption has been described as resting partly on socialization, through which newcomers come to see corrupt practices as acceptable (Ashforth and Anand, 2003). In a cross-level field study, the antisocial behavior of employees' coworkers was positively related to employees' own antisocial behavior (Robinson and O'Leary-Kelly, 1998), and a meta-analysis found that characteristics of the organizational environment, including ethical climate and culture, were associated with unethical choices alongside individual and issue characteristics (Kish-Gephart et al., 2010).

Our argument follows from treating enacted-norm clarity as the channel through which a unit's norms reach a newcomer's conduct. The clearer the newcomer's grasp of what the unit actually practices, the more that practice should shape the newcomer's conduct, in whichever direction it points. If distributed entry lowers clarity, it should weaken the unit's influence in both directions. Where enacted norms are ethical, distance is a loss: newcomers pick up less of the integrity their colleagues practice. Where misconduct has been normalized, distance may offer partial protection, because newcomers absorb less of it. In both cases, a distant newcomer's conduct should reflect more of what the newcomer brought to the job and of the formal rules the newcomer was taught. We know of no study that has tested this.

Clarity does not guarantee conformity. A newcomer who clearly sees that misconduct is normal in a unit may recognize it as misconduct and resist or leave. The normalization literature, however, describes how newcomers are drawn into misconduct gradually rather than confronted with it all at once, a process that tends to blunt such recognition (Ashforth and Anand, 2003). Our claim concerns the average tendency during entry, when newcomers have little power and are still working toward social acceptance (Bauer et al., 2007); newcomers with strong personal ethical commitments are a likely exception, which we note as a boundary condition.

Proposition 3. Enacted-norm clarity strengthens the relationship between the ethical quality of a work unit's enacted norms and newcomers' ethical conduct. Consequently, distributed entry weakens that relationship, whether the unit's enacted norms are ethical or not.

The limit of narration noted above implies an asymmetry that we flag for future research rather than state as a proposition. Because leaders rarely narrate misconduct, narration should restore the transmission of ethical norms more than the transmission of normalized misconduct.

4.6 Persistence Beyond Entry

Imprinting theory predicts that what is formed during a sensitive period persists after conditions change (Marquis and Tilcsik, 2013). Evidence at the individual level is consistent with this: conditions at the time of hire have been linked to approaches that shaped later performance (Tilcsik, 2014), and early exposure to an adviser’s orientation has been linked to later professional choices (Azoulay et al., 2017). We extend this reasoning to ethics. The ethical schemas a newcomer forms at entry, including the gaps left by limited observation, should shape how the newcomer reads later situations, so that later exposure is interpreted through them rather than replacing them.

There is a reasonable counterargument. Enacted norms are reinforced continually, and a newcomer who later works alongside colleagues has many chances to relearn them. Socialization also continues well beyond entry (Van Maanen and Schein, 1979). We therefore frame persistence as a comparison: we do not predict that later exposure has no effect, only that it does not fully close the difference created at entry.

Proposition 4. Differences in ethical conduct that arise from distributed entry persist beyond the entry period: newcomers who entered at a distance continue to differ from co-located entrants in how closely their conduct follows the unit’s enacted norms, even after their observational access has become comparable.

4.7 Entry Conditions, Not Birth Cohort

We frame the model around Generation Z because members of this cohort who began office-based careers in the early 2020s did so when working from home spread widely (Kniffin et al., 2021). It is likely, although we have found no data that establish it, that many of them spent part of their entry period at a distance. How many did so is an empirical question we do not try to answer here, and the answer is likely to vary by occupation and country.

Our model does not treat birth cohort as the cause. Reviews of generational research have found cohort differences in work attitudes and values to be small or inconsistent and difficult to separate from age and period (Costanza et al., 2012; Parry and Urwin, 2011; Rudolph et al., 2021), although some researchers maintain that generational differences are real and useful (Campbell et al., 2015). The model’s reasoning is closer to Mannheim’s original point that shared formative experiences, not shared birth years, are what can make a cohort into a generation (Mannheim, 1952). In organizational terms, the relevant unit is what Joshi et al. (2010) call a cohort-based generation, formed by entering an organization at the same time, rather than an age-based one. Imprinting research makes the same distinction when it separates imprints from cohort effects (Marquis and Tilcsik, 2013).

Proposition 5. The relationships in Propositions 1 to 4 depend on the conditions of organizational entry rather than on birth cohort: newcomers from older cohorts who enter at a distance show the same patterns as members of Generation Z who enter at a distance, and members of Generation Z who enter co-located do not show them.

If this proposition holds, the label Generation Z describes a population whose timing of entry coincided with a condition, not a cause of that condition’s effects.

5 Discussion and Implications

5.1 Theoretical Implications

Each implication below depends on the propositions receiving support.

For ethical leadership and social learning research, the model makes an assumption visible. The case for role modeling rests on followers being able to see their models and the consequences of their models’ conduct (Brown et al., 2005; Brown and Treviño, 2006). Observational access turns that assumption into a variable, and leader ethical narration identifies a path by which ethical leadership can work when observation is limited. This is consistent with the view that vicarious learning can take place through conversation as well as through watching (Myers, 2018), and it suggests that the communicative side of ethical leadership may matter more, relative to silent example, when teams are distributed.

For socialization research, the model suggests that physical arrangements belong in the analysis of socialization tactics. Van Maanen and Schein’s contrast between serial socialization, in which newcomers learn from predecessors, and disjunctive socialization, in which they have none to learn from (Van Maanen and Schein, 1979), was framed in terms of whether predecessors exist. Distributed entry may produce a hidden form of disjunctive socialization in which predecessors exist but are seldom seen. If so, an organization could believe it socializes newcomers serially while newcomers experience something closer to the opposite.

For imprinting research, the model proposes that ethical norms can be imprinted in the same way that approaches to work and professional orientations have been shown to be (Tilcsik, 2014; Azoulay et al., 2017). It also specifies an imprint defined partly by absence: what a newcomer did not observe at entry may shape later conduct as much as what the newcomer did observe.

For generational research, the model offers a way to keep the idea of a formative period without relying on birth-year categories. Critics have argued that birth cohorts explain little about work attitudes (Costanza and Finkelstein, 2015; Rudolph and Zacher, 2017). Defining the relevant cohort by shared conditions of entry (Joshi et al., 2010) yields claims that can be tested directly, because entry conditions can be measured for newcomers of any age.

For behavioral ethics, the two-sided effect in Proposition 3 implies that the ethical consequences of distributed work should differ across units. Research that estimates an average effect of remote work on misconduct could find little or nothing even if the model is correct, because losses in ethical units and partial protection in units with normalized misconduct would offset each other.

5.2 Practical Implications

The suggestions that follow are hypotheses for practice derived from the propositions, not recommendations backed by evidence.

Supervisors of distributed newcomers may need to say out loud what co-located newcomers would have seen. Explaining why a borderline request was refused, or what followed when a rule was ignored, is the behavior the moral manager concept describes (Treviño et al., 2000), and in our model it is the main available substitute for observation. Making the consequences of conduct visible, which ethical culture research treats as one dimension of an ethical organization (Kaptein, 2008), serves the same purpose, although it has to be balanced against the confidentiality owed to the people involved.

Organizations that rely on codes and online training to onboard remote newcomers should not assume that these convey the practiced norms, since those formal elements are distinct from the informal ones that carry enacted norms (Tenbrunsel et al., 2003). Where in-person time is limited, scheduling part of it early in the entry period, and around work in which ethical judgment is exercised, is one way to raise observational access when it matters most. That timing recommendation is our inference from imprinting theory, not an established finding. Structured, shared entry experiences of the kind associated with institutionalized socialization tactics (Ashforth and Saks, 1996) may also help. Because newcomers obtain normative information largely from peers (Morrison, 1993), pairing distant newcomers with well-chosen peers is another option.

Newcomers themselves are not passive in this process. Remote newcomers have been observed seeking out insiders to make up for the contact they lacked (Paik and Gilmore, 2026). The model suggests that the most useful questions for a distant newcomer are about cases rather than rules: how a particular difficult request was handled, and what happened to the people involved. Such questions still carry image costs (Ashford et al., 2003), which is one reason the burden should not rest on newcomers alone.

Finally, the two-sided effect has an uncomfortable implication. In units where misconduct has become normal, distance may partly protect newcomers, but it does nothing to change the unit. Such units require changes to the enacted norms themselves (Ashforth and Anand, 2003).

5.3 A Testing Agenda

The propositions can be tested with established designs, but new measures are needed first. Observational access, enacted-norm clarity, and leader ethical narration have no validated measures. Enacted-norm clarity could be assessed by asking newcomers how conduct in specific gray-area situations is actually handled in their unit and comparing their answers with those of experienced insiders. Observational access could be measured by asking how often newcomers have witnessed colleagues or supervisors deal with ethically charged situations and learned what followed. Existing instruments can cover the other constructs: ethical leadership (Brown et al., 2005), ethical culture including its transparency dimension (Kaptein, 2008), coworker antisocial behavior as an indicator of normalized misconduct (Robinson and O’Leary-Kelly, 1998), newcomer information seeking (Morrison, 1993), and professional isolation (Golden et al., 2008).

The most informative field design would compare distributed and co-located entrants within the same organizations. Newcomers are not randomly assigned to distributed entry, and remote roles may differ from on-site ones in function and autonomy, so such comparisons need to address selection. Changes in onboarding policy, such as a move from remote to on-site onboarding at a given date, create entry cohorts that differ in their conditions of entry while sharing an organization, a logic similar to that of studies using organization-wide changes in work arrangements (Yang et al., 2022). Measuring enacted-norm clarity during entry and conduct afterwards would test Propositions 1 to 3. Following both groups after their working arrangements converge would test Proposition 4. Including older entrants, such as career changers, in both conditions is what makes Proposition 5 testable.

Because newcomers are nested in work units, and Proposition 3 involves the norms of the unit, the natural analytic framework is multilevel, with the ethical quality of enacted norms measured at the unit level and its interaction with enacted-norm clarity or distributed entry tested across levels. The entry period also needs an explicit definition in each study, for example the first several months of tenure, and enacted-norm clarity should be measured more than once within it, since the model concerns how quickly and how completely newcomers learn the enacted norms.

Scenario experiments can complement field work. Participants could be shown the same work situation with or without the opportunity to observe how a colleague’s shortcut was handled, and with or without a supervisor’s explanation, and then asked what the unit’s norm is and what they would do. Such designs support causal inference about Propositions 1 and 2, but they measure inferences and intentions rather than conduct, so field evidence would still be needed. Research on normalized misconduct also raises its own ethical questions, and studies of Proposition 3 would need strong protections for participants.

5.4 Boundary Conditions and Ways the Model Could Fail

Several conditions should weaken the proposed relationships. Structured socialization programs that give distributed newcomers regular, shared contact with insiders may preserve observational access despite distance (Ashforth and Saks, 1996). Newcomers with substantial prior work experience bring ethical schemas formed elsewhere, and research on career history suggests that such prior experience carries over (Dokko et al., 2009; Higgins, 2005); for them, the entry period in a new organization should matter less than it does for people entering a first professional job. Newcomers with strong personal ethical commitments may resist normalized misconduct even when they see it clearly, which would weaken Proposition 3 in units where misconduct is normal.

The details of distributed arrangements matter too. Teams that work largely through synchronous video and open channels may give newcomers more visibility than their physical separation implies, in line with evidence that visible digital communication lets observers learn about colleagues (Leonardi, 2015). Hybrid arrangements also vary in whether newcomers and the people they learn from are in the office on the same days, which may matter more than the number of days either spends there. Occupational and national context may matter as well. Where professional bodies or regulators set detailed rules of conduct, formal norms may leave less room for the unit’s enacted norms, and the model’s effects should be smaller.

The model could also be wrong, and its propositions are designed so that this can be detected. The main rival is a monitoring account, in which distance reduces supervision and so increases the opportunity for misconduct in every unit. That account predicts that distributed entrants behave less ethically regardless of their unit’s norms. Our model predicts a crossover, with distributed entrants behaving less ethically than co-located entrants in ethical units but adopting less misconduct in units where it is normal. If the crossover does not appear, Proposition 3 fails and the monitoring account gains support. If differences between distributed and co-located entrants disappear once their working arrangements converge, Proposition 4 fails, which would suggest that ethical learning lost at entry can be recovered later. If members of Generation Z differ from older newcomers who entered under the same conditions, Proposition 5 fails, and some cohort effect beyond entry conditions would need explaining.

5.5 Limitations

The paper reports no data, and none of its propositions has been tested. Three of its constructs are new and unmeasured. Distributed entry covers a wide range of arrangements, and the model treats it as a single dimension. We do not estimate how many members of Generation Z experienced distributed entry, and that share probably differs across occupations and countries. In our reading, research on remote onboarding is still thin,

and most of the literature the model draws on comes from North American and European organizations. Measuring ethical conduct is difficult in any study, and self-reports of it are vulnerable to socially desirable responding.

6 Conclusion

Discussions of Generation Z and workplace ethics usually ask what this cohort values. This paper has asked a different question: how members of the cohort learned the ethics that are actually practiced where they work, given that many of them entered office-based work when distributed arrangements were spreading. Drawing on social learning theory and imprinting theory, it proposed that distributed entry lowers newcomers' clarity about enacted ethical norms by reducing their observational access to ethical conduct, that leaders who narrate the ethical reasoning behind their decisions can offset part of that loss, and that distance weakens the transmission of enacted norms whether those norms are ethical or not. It further proposed that the resulting differences outlast the entry period and that they follow the conditions of entry rather than birth cohort. The main takeaway is that the channel through which newcomers learn workplace ethics deserves as much attention as the values they bring with them. The main limitation is that the model is untested and three of its constructs still lack measures. A useful next step would be to compare distributed and co-located entrants within the same organizations, including older entrants, and to follow both groups after their working arrangements converge. Such a study would show whether the ethical imprint of distributed entry is real, whether it lasts, and whether it belongs to a generation or to a set of entry conditions that any newcomer might face.

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